Tibetan rebels. Instead, it chose to look the other way. Its turning a blind eye was not motivated by a desire to push the Chinese out of Tibet; instead, it arose from a growing view that China was violating the 1954 agreement on Tibet's autonomy. Delhi felt that a degree of pressure on Beijing might act as a check on unbridled Chinese actions.[56]

Whatever Indian motives, officials in Beijing in 1956 would see a picture that was disturbing – a rebellion in eastern Tibet, the Dalai Lama in Delhi seeking political asylum, and American aid to the Khampa resistance. China could be excused for thinking that the three were interrelated. By the summer of 1958, the rebellion in Tibet was gathering force and moving from the eastern part of the province towards Lhasa. Chinese forces were surrounded at Zedong and Dongqing, and these fell to the rebels in early 1959.[57] On 10 March 1959, Lhasa too finally saw the beginnings of rebellion. Beijing decided now to administer the region directly. As Chinese troops massed in strength and threatened the Potala Palace (which housed the Dalai Lama), he slipped out of Lhasa from his summer palace, Norbulinka. On 31 March, he crossed the border into India, where he was given asylum. He was soon joined by thousands of other Tibetans.

India for its part was upset by Beijing's actions which eroded the autonomy that Delhi thought it had secured by its support of the 1951 and 1954 Tibet accords. After the Dalai Lama's arrival in India, Nehru himself, the Indian government, and the aroused public certainly made their feelings known. There were street protests. India banned foodgrain exports to China. Indira Gandhi helped organize an all-party relief committee for Tibetan refugees.[58] Later, India would ban steel products, hand tools, auto parts, fuel, clothing, tea, and sugar to Tibet. The prime minister went to Mussoorie to meet the Dalai Lama, and he edited the Tibetan leader's 18 April 1959 official statement.[59] In a speech in Parliament on 27 April 1959, Nehru made clear that India did not support Tibetan independence but found itself in sympathy with the call to restore Tibet's eroding autonomy. Indian policy, he stated, would be governed by security concerns, by its 'desire to maintain friendly relations with China', and its 'deep sympathy for the